the wine to the black marketeer? As he studied her face, her muscles tensed and she felt like she'd run an enormous distance but still wasn't any closer to her goal.

He handed her the basket and proceeded to the salon. "Wait here. I'll bring him to you."

First step. Léa doubted he'd leave her alone with Édouard. She'd use a coded language.

A few moments later, Édouard, looking terrible, his face drawn and his eyes red with exhaustion, was escorted into the hall by the soldier, who stationed himself nearby to overhear the conversation.

"Léa, thank you for coming—and for the supplies."

Fearing she didn't have much time, she said, "Two vats have a strange odor and when I opened the doors, the bubbling ceased." She swallowed. "What should I do? I don't want to disappoint Weinführer Brucker with less ethanol than he's expecting."

Confusion shaded Édouard's face. *Please, Édouard, this is important.*

"Did you check the temperature?"

"Oh yes, it's . . ."

"Too low?" he prompted.

She nodded. Thank God. He was reading between the lines of what she was saying. "It all started the night the donkey brayed without stop. We considered taking him to the river, to cool him down but Virginie warned he was too stubborn to go."

The soldier looked at her, suspicion in his eyes.

"A slight change in air temperature can start the donkey braying. Maybe the animal senses a storm. But it often corresponds to a problem with the fermentation process. Have you stirred the lees?"

"What is that?"

"Sediment at the bottom of the tank. Stir it with the baton by the vats. The bubbling should return after a few hours."

"Thank you," she said, handing him the basket. "Virginie wants to know what you need. She's busy with Paulette. Rose helps me." Léa met his eyes. "She's the key."

He nodded and his eyes shone bright, perhaps with recognition of their plan to use the tunnel to transport the wine to the smuggler. "Tell Virginie that a book would be nice to read if she could include one next time. Oh,